

THE SECOND GLASS

Written by

Written by

James & Maya – a oner

Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. SUBURBAN HOUSE - NIGHT

Black. Then rooftops – the flat blue dark of a cul-de-sac asleep.

The camera hangs high above one house. A single downstairs window burns gold against all that blue.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, unhurried, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open an inch –

INT. HOUSE - KITCHEN / LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

– and into the warmth.

A kettle ticks as it cools. Two mugs wait on the counter. One steams. One is stone cold.

MAYA, 30s, coat still on, stands at the island. Her phone lies face-down under her flat palm, pinned there. Everything about her day is finished except this.

JAMES, 30s, is at the counter with a tea towel, drying a plate. He has been drying the same plate for some time.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. But something in him eases – the small give of a body that has decided it isn't alone.

MAYA
I moved the call to seven-thirty.

JAMES
Okay.

MAYA
That's the second time this week. I don't move calls. I moved it so we could do this properly.

JAMES
We're doing it.

MAYA
You're drying a plate.

He looks at the plate like someone just put it in his hands.

He sets it down. Picks up the cold mug – the one that never steamed – and slides it two inches to the left. Squares it against nothing.

The camera drifts closer. His head tips, a fraction, toward the space beside him. Toward it.

MAYA (CONT'D)

There. That.

JAMES

What.

MAYA

You went. Right in the middle of a sentence, you just – left.

JAMES

I'm standing in the kitchen.

MAYA

Half of you. The other half's off somewhere I don't get invited.

He crosses to the back door and opens it. Cold air. He props it with his heel, then his foot, then leaves it – an inch, like the window.

JAMES

It gets stuffy.

MAYA

It's November.

JAMES

Do you want it shut?

MAYA

I want you to notice you opened it.

The camera slides between them, slow, a low arc – and James's eyes follow it across the room. Not her. It. The empty air where it moves.

Maya watches him watch nothing.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Who are you looking at.

JAMES

(beat)

Nothing. The — the light does a thing on the wall.

MAYA

The light does a thing on the wall.

JAMES

Yeah.

MAYA

I schedule us. Do you understand that? I put us in the calendar in a colour, so there's a version of this where you're actually here, and I am sitting in it alone.

James pulls out the second stool at the island. Sets it straight. Doesn't sit on it. Leaves it out, angled, ready — for no one at the island but her.

She stares at the empty stool.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Who's the stool for.

JAMES

(not hearing it)

Sorry?

The camera lifts and comes in over his shoulder, close now, close as breath, hanging at the side of his face. He goes very still. He almost — almost — turns his cheek toward it.

MAYA (CONT'D)

I asked who the stool is for.

He surfaces. Looks at the stool. Looks at her. Pushes the stool back in, too hard, so it knocks the island.

JAMES

Habit. It's a stool, Maya.

MAYA

Right.

She takes her hand off the phone. Picks it up. This is the tell that she's done deciding.

MAYA (CONT'D)

I used to think you looked at me like you were remembering me. And I told myself that was a nice thing. That's how far I'll bend, it turns out. I'll call it nice.

JAMES

That's not – that's not fair.

MAYA

No.

She buttons the coat that was already buttoned. Checks a button that was already done. The wall goes up brick by brick, in real time, and it is the most honest thing she does all night.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Lock the door after me. Both of them.

JAMES

Maya –

MAYA

The seven-thirty's real. I do have to go.

She doesn't. They both know she doesn't. She goes anyway.

The camera does not follow her.

It stays with James. The front door opens off-frame. A wash of cold. It clicks shut.

Silence, except the kettle, ticking down to nothing.

James stands alone in the middle of the room. His hand comes up, slow, and hangs in the air beside him – palm open, at a height, as if to rest on a shoulder that should be there.

The camera drifts into that space. Right into it. Fills the place where his hand is reaching. Warm. Familiar. Waiting to be touched.

His fingers are an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. Really sees it – sees what he's doing, sees the reach, sees the room, sees the two mugs and the crooked stool and the open door and the whole shape of the evening laid out like evidence.

His face breaks.

JAMES (CONT'D)
 (barely)
 No.

He steps back from it.

JAMES (CONT'D)
 No. Not – not now. Not tonight.

The camera follows him. Gentle. It doesn't understand. It comes closer.

JAMES (CONT'D)
 (a roar, ragged, at the
 empty air)
 FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS – a hard rush back, away from him, across the room, low over the counter, past the cold mug, out through the gap in the window where it came –

EXT. SUBURBAN HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

– out into the cold and UP, fast, climbing hard, the gold window shrinking beneath it.

It stops, high above the roof, and looks down.

Down at the little lit house. Down at the one warm window with the man standing in it, small now, both hands over his face.

The camera holds there in the dark, tilted down – the way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.